Tamil Nadu
where stories never end

OFFBEAT DESTINATIONS

Along the Tamil Nadu Coast

The coastline of Tamil Nadu offers many unusual and interesting attractions beyond the well-known destinations.

Like a necklace of precious stones, the Tamil Nadu coast is dotted with popular tourist attractions, ranging from the vibrant capital Chennai to the stunning beaches of the Coromandel Coast and ancient heritage monuments with a UNESCO World Heritage tag. This charmed coast also has several surprises in store. Beyond the popular destinations, there are lesser-known places offering an offbeat experience..



PICHAVARAM

Thirty minutes from the temple town of Chidambaram lies Pichavaram, the second-largest mangrove forest in the world. The picturesque backwaters, network of canals, and silvery beaches make Pichavaram an ideal ecotourism destination. A boat ride through the mangroves is both memorable and educative. As the boat glides through the inner canals under the canopy of the mangroves, you can spot several water birds like storks, snipes, egrets, cormorants, herons, spoonbills and pelicans. TTDC operates the Pichavaram Boat House which offers row boats as well as motor boats for rides through the mangroves.

THARANGAMBADI

The charming coastal town of Tharangambadi (aka Tranquebar) in Mayiladuthurai district was set up in 1620 as the first Danish trading post in India. You can go on a



heritage walk to see key sights like the Dansborg Fort, Danish Cemetery, and New Jerusalem Church. Said to be a blend of Tamil and Chinese architectural styles, the 13th-century Masilamani Nathar Temple is one of the few shore temples in India and features exquisite carvings. Ziegenbalg House, a museum on intercultural dialogue, makes for an illuminating visit. Being on the coast, fish features prominently in the local cuisine. Kanangeluthi (mackerel) fry is a popular snack. Local fishes used in the curries are black parai (black trevally) nethili (anchovy) and seer fish. A spice paste with a predominance of coriander and black pepper is distinctive of the region

VELANKANNI

This spiritual tourism destination in Nagapattinam district attracts the devout from all faiths. Velankanni was once a thriving port with trade links to Rome and Greece. Today, its biggest draw is the Basilica of Our Lady of Good Health, an important pilgrimage spot.



CUDDALORE

Cuddalore is a multi-faceted destination, great for leisure travellers as well as seekers of peace. The scenic Silver Beach is the second-longest beach on the Coromandel Coast. The draw for heritage enthusiasts is Fort St. David, named after the patron saint of Wales. Cuddalore is also home to famous temples like the Devanathaswamy Temple and the Sri Veeratteswarar Temple.

DHANUSHKODI

Dhanushkodi is a former settlement on Pamban Island which was abandoned after the 1964 Rameswaram Cyclone. Arichal Munai is the island's end point where the waters of the Bay of Bengal and Indian Ocean merge. The abandoned church, railway station and post office stand as surreal witnesses to the cyclone's fury. Don't miss the new lighthouse inaugurated in 2022. Dhanuskodi is also a nesting site for the endangered Olive Ridley turtles.



KURUSADAI ISLAND

This island in the Gulf of Mannar about 20 kilometres from the holy coastal town of Rameswaram is a marine wonderland surrounded by coral reefs, fish and dolphins. Set between Pamban Island and the mainland, it has been opened up to ecotourism with boat rides to the island. The community eco-tourism project will benefit the local communities.

THOOTHUKUDI

The bustling port city of Thoothukudi (aka Tuticorin) will sweep you away with its charm. Besides beautiful beaches, the 'Pearl City' also offers watersports, including scuba diving, windsurfing and kite surfing. Wakeboarding, kayaking, stand-up paddle boarding and fishing are some other activities on offer. The stunning Manapad Beach is popular for film shoots. You will also find the 16th-century Holy Cross Church in Manapad. The church was built around 1540 after a storm-struck Portuguese ship found safe haven here. South of Thoothukudi, the coastal town of Thiruchendur has a magical beach as well as an ancient temple dedicated to Lord Murugan.

With these and other offbeat destinations, the Tamil Nadu coastline has a surprise at every turn.